Chapter 3

Achieving Mental and Emotional Health

1. Developing Your Self-Esteem
2. Developing Personal Identity and Character
3. Expressing Emotions in Healthful Ways

Lesson 1 — Developing Your Self-Esteem

What Is Mental and Emotional Health?

Mental and emotional health is your ability to accept yourself and others, express and manage your emotions, and handle the demands and challenges life throws at you. When you're struggling emotionally it often shows up as poor sleep, unhealthy eating, or strained relationships.

Signs of Good Mental and Emotional Health

- **Sense of belonging** — Feeling connected to family, friends, and your community
- **Sense of purpose** — Believing your life has meaning and direction
- **Positive outlook** — Seeing the bright side even when things are hard
- **Self-sufficiency** — Trusting yourself to make responsible decisions
- **Healthy self-esteem** — Believing in your own worth, even when you make mistakes

People with good mental and emotional health are **resilient** — they have the ability to adapt and bounce back from disappointment, difficulty, or crisis. Everyone faces hard times; resilience is what helps you get through them.

Building Self-Esteem

Self-esteem is how much you value, respect, and feel confident about yourself. It shapes your outlook and influences the health choices you make. It grows when you push through challenges and use **positive self-talk** — the encouraging inner voice that reminds you of your worth.

✓ Choose friends who genuinely value and respect you

- ✓ Replace negative self-talk with supportive self-talk
- ✓ See mistakes as learning opportunities, not failures
- ✓ Try new activities to discover your strengths
- ✓ Volunteer — helping others is one of the fastest ways to feel good about yourself
- ✓ Focus on progress, not perfection

Maslow's Hierarchy of Needs

Psychologist Abraham Maslow created a model explaining what motivates human growth. The **hierarchy of needs** is a ranked list of needs essential to development, starting at the most basic and building upward:

- Physical needs — Food, water, sleep, shelter
- Safety needs — Being secure from danger
- Belonging needs — Love, connection, feeling accepted
- Esteem needs — Feeling valued and recognized
- Self-actualization — Reaching your full potential

> The key: you need to meet lower-level needs before you can focus on higher ones. And it matters HOW you meet those needs — joining a gang to feel accepted, for example, is a high-risk behavior that damages all sides of your health.

Lesson 2 — Developing Personal Identity and Character

Your Personal Identity

Your **personal identity** is your sense of yourself as a unique individual — your values, interests, beliefs, strengths, and relationships. It's shaped by your family, culture, friendships, and experiences, and continues developing throughout your teen years and beyond.

The 6 Traits of Good Character

Trustworthiness	Honest, reliable, and loyal. You do what you say you'll do.
Respect	Treat people and their property with care, even when you disagree.
Responsibility	Think before you act, own your choices, and follow through.
Fairness	Play by the rules, share, and don't take advantage of others.
Caring	Show kindness, gratitude, and compassion toward others.

Citizenship	Contribute to your school and community, follow laws, advocate for a healthy environment.

A person of good character demonstrates these values consistently through **integrity** — living by core ethical values even when no one is watching.

Building a Healthy Identity

- Know your strengths AND weaknesses — honestly and without being too hard on yourself
- Surround yourself with positive, supportive people
- Develop a sense of purpose through short-term and long-term goals
- Build meaningful relationships — people who give you constructive criticism are your most valuable supporters
- Give back to your community through volunteering

Lesson 3 — Expressing Emotions in Healthful Ways

Understanding Your Emotions

Emotions are signals that tell your mind and body how to react. They're neither good nor bad — what matters is how you choose to express them. During the teen years, **hormones** can make emotions feel more intense and unpredictable. According to the CDC, about **40% of high school students** reported persistent sadness or hopelessness in 2023.

Common Emotions

Happiness	Feeling satisfied and positive; brings energy and creativity
Sadness	A normal reaction to loss or disappointment — it's okay to feel sad
Love	Deep affection, care, and respect for someone
Fear	A natural response to danger; can become a problem if it stops healthy risk-taking
Guilt	Regret when you act against your values — sometimes felt over things beyond your control
Anger	Normal reaction to hurt or harm — becomes **hostility** when intentionally harmful toward others

Managing Your Emotions

When emotions feel overwhelming: take slow deep breaths, relax your muscles, remove yourself from the situation, write in a private journal, or talk to someone you trust.

Some people use **defense mechanisms** — mental processes that protect from intense emotional pain. Common ones: Repression, Denial, Projection, Rationalization, Suppression, Regression, and Compensation. These can provide short-term relief, but relying on them too long prevents you from solving the actual problem.

> Tip for managing anger: When you feel it building, PAUSE. Try deep breathing, remove yourself from the situation, channel the energy into something physical, or talk it out. Empathy — understanding how the other person feels — can also help you cool down and see the full picture.

Chapter Vocabulary

Lesson 1

Mental/emotional health	The ability to accept yourself and others, express and manage emotions, and deal with the demands and challenges of life
Resilient	Having the ability to adapt effectively and recover from disappointment, difficulty, or crisis
Self-esteem	How much you value, respect, and feel confident about yourself
Competence	Having enough skills to do something successfully
Hierarchy of needs	A ranked list of needs essential to human growth and development, from basic physical needs up to reaching your full potential
Self-actualization	The drive to reach your full potential and become the best version of yourself

Lesson 2

Personal identity	Your sense of yourself as a unique individual, shaped by your values, relationships, experiences, and beliefs
Role model	Someone whose success or behavior serves as an example for others
Personality	The complex set of characteristics that makes a person unique
Character	The distinctive qualities that describe how a person thinks, feels, and behaves
Integrity	A firm, consistent commitment to core ethical values
Constructive criticism	Honest, non-hostile feedback that points out problems and encourages improvement

Lesson 3

Emotions	Signals that tell your mind and body how to react to situations
Hormones	Chemicals produced by your glands that regulate the activities of different body cells
Hostility	The intentional use of unfriendly or offensive behavior toward others
Empathy	The ability to imagine and understand how someone else feels
Defense mechanisms	Mental processes that protect individuals from strong or stressful emotions and situations